

Existence, rightly-ordered, is goodness. God, being Himself the ultimate good, is the fullness of existence – that is, when individuals more closely align themselves with God, they more fully exist. Because God is an objective reality, goodness is an objective reality. Goodness, more specifically, is the fulfillment of an entity's nature and purpose (its existence). Everything has a nature and a purpose. A chair, for example, has a nature and a purpose. A chair's nature is that it is a chair – it is an elevated, flat surface; oftentimes a chair is elevated by legs and has a backrest. A chair's purpose is to comfortably seat individuals. When a chair does not meet the fullness of either its nature or purpose, then it fails to fully exist. For example, a chair may not meet the fullness of its nature if it is missing a leg. Likewise, a chair does not satisfy its true purpose if it fails at comfortably seating individuals. However, chairs whose nature and purpose are rightly-ordered have reached their fullest potential of existence.

Evil is the privation of good. When individuals fall short of their rightly-ordered relationship with God – contradicting their nature (as people made in the image of God) and their purpose (to love God) – they are less good and more evil. Since existence, rightly-ordered, is goodness and goodness is objective in God, those who have a broken relationship with God have a broken existence. The chair whose leg is missing is evil. The chair that fails to comfortably seat individuals is evil. The chair that is evil has not reached its fullness of existence.

However, just because something is evil does not mean that it deserves punishment. There are two types of evil: moral evil and physical evil. Moral evil is the freewill rejection of good. Acts of moral evil are sins. On the other hand, physical evil is a privation of good that exists not through willful choice but as a result of imperfection in Creation. Physical evil includes disease, suffering, natural disasters, and death – none of which are sinful, but all of which are evil. Moral evils are clearly not rightly-ordered because they are an individual's decided rejection of goodness (and, by extension, God). Physical evils are also not rightly-ordered, but these physical evils are not necessarily the fault of the subject. Physical evils exist as a disruption in the natural order because of the limitations of created reality which is neither perfect nor infinite. A broken chair can not be the agent of moral evil; it is not sentient so it can not make free will decisions to reject good. As such, the evil, broken chair does not earn itself punishment. A broken chair is however the subject of physical evil. There is still a privation of good in both the nature and purpose of the broken chair. This evil is a consequence of its existence in created reality – it can not be perfect so it must suffer the consequences of Creation's brokenness.

While a broken chair might be an accurate manifestation of physical evil, it does not give a full picture of evil on its own. Human beings are the pinnacle of Creation, and, as much as God loves all of Creation as His own, God especially desires to be in a right relationship with humanity. Being made in God's own image, humans are rightly-ordered when they live in a right relationship with God, themselves, and the rest of Creation (they are expected to do this in spite of their suffering the physical evils of Creation's brokenness). Thus, out of their sentience and moral agency, humans differ from chairs in that they have the ability to respond to their evil brokenness and move toward a fuller realization of their existence in God.

